

17 Rebekah

The bold young woman who said "I will go," and later took her family's future into her own hands.

Rebekah enters the Bible at a well, drawing water for a stranger and all ten of his camels. He was Abraham's servant, sent to find a wife for Isaac, and he saw her kindness as God's answer to prayer. Asked whether she would leave home at once, she said simply, "I will go." She became Isaac's beloved wife and received a word from God about her twin sons. Later she planned the deception that won Jacob his father's blessing. It cost her dearly: she sent Jacob away, and Genesis never records that she saw him again.

At a glance

Name	Rebekah; "Rebecca" in Romans 9:10; meaning uncertain
Family	Daughter of Bethuel; sister of Laban; wife of Isaac
Home	"The city of Nahor" in Padan-aram (Genesis 24:10)
Key places	The well at Nahor; Beer-lahai-roi; Gerar; Beersheba
Key people	Isaac, Abraham's servant, Laban, Esau, Jacob, her nurse Deborah
Burial	The cave of Machpelah (Genesis 49:31)
Main passages	Genesis 24:1–67; 25:19–28; 26:6–11, 34–35; 27:1–28:5
New Testament	Romans 9:10–12

"And they called Rebekah, and said unto her, Wilt thou go with this man? And she said, I will go."

Genesis 24:58, KJV

The life of Rebekah

Genesis gives no ages for Rebekah. Isaac's ages come from Genesis 25:20 and 25:26.

At the well	● Waters the camels Abraham's servant prays for a sign. Before he finishes, Rebekah comes out, gives him a drink, and offers to draw water for all his camels. <i>Genesis 24:12-27</i>
At home	● Agrees to go Her brother Laban and father Bethuel agree that "the thing proceedeth from the LORD." Asked if she will go, she agrees, and her family blesses her. <i>Genesis 24:28-61</i>
Isaac age 40	● Marries Isaac She sees Isaac in the field, covers herself with a veil, and becomes his wife. He loves her and is comforted after his mother's death. <i>Genesis 24:62-67; 25:20</i>
Isaac age 60	● Bears twins After twenty years of barrenness, Isaac prays and she conceives. The children struggle within her, so she asks the LORD why. He tells her, "The elder shall serve the younger." <i>Genesis 25:21-26</i>
In Gerar	● Called a sister During a famine Isaac tells the men of Gerar that she is his sister, until King Abimelech sees them together and protects her. <i>Genesis 26:6-11</i>
Isaac old and blind	● Plans the deception She overhears Isaac promise Esau a blessing. She dresses Jacob in Esau's clothes, covers his hands with goatskins, and cooks the meal herself. <i>Genesis 27:1-17</i>
After the blessing	● Sends Jacob away Learning that Esau plans to kill Jacob, she urges Jacob to flee to Laban and persuades Isaac to send him there to find a wife. <i>Genesis 27:41-28:5</i>

Key activities

Many readers believe Rebekah acted because of God's word that "the elder shall serve the younger" (Genesis 25:23). Genesis does not say so. It shows both God's purpose and the harm done by deceit.

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- 1 **Served a stranger.** She gave a traveler a drink and then offered, unasked, to water all his camels too. *Genesis 24:17-20*
 - 2 **Chose to go.** She left her family at once for a husband she had never met. *Genesis 24:57-61*
 - 3 **Comforted Isaac.** She became the wife Isaac loved, and she comforted him after Sarah's death. *Genesis 24:67*
 - 4 **Took her question to God.** When her pregnancy troubled her, "she went to enquire of the LORD." *Genesis 25:22-23*
 - 5 **Loved Jacob.** "Rebekah loved Jacob," while Isaac loved Esau. *Genesis 25:28*
 - 6 **Grieved over Esau's wives.** His Hittite wives were "a grief of mind unto Isaac and to Rebekah." *Genesis 26:34-35; 27:46*
 - 7 **Directed the deception.** She told Jacob, "Upon me be thy curse, my son: only obey my voice." *Genesis 27:5-17*
 - 8 **Protected Jacob.** She sent him away to Haran "a few days" that became twenty years. *Genesis 27:42-45; 31:41*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Rebekah.

Old Testament

Genesis 22:20–23	Her birth is reported to Abraham: "Bethuel begat Rebekah."
Genesis 24–27	This is the main account of her life.
Genesis 35:8	"Deborah Rebekah's nurse" dies and is buried near Bethel.
Genesis 49:31	Jacob says, "There they buried Isaac and Rebekah his wife."

New Testament

Romans 9:10–13	Paul points out that God's word came to Rebecca before her sons were born, "neither having done any good or evil," so that God's choice would rest "not of works, but of him that calleth."
Echoes	Like the servant at the well, Jesus meets a woman at a well (John 4:6–7). Mary, mother of Jesus, also gives a ready yes to God's call: "be it unto me according to thy word" (Luke 1:38).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Rebekah do for Abraham's servant beyond what he asked (Genesis 24:17–20)?
2. *Understand:* God had told Rebekah that the elder would serve the younger. Do you think she needed to scheme for it to happen? Why or why not?
3. *Apply:* Rebekah said, "I will go." Where is God asking you for a ready yes right now?
4. *Apply:* Rebekah favored one son. How can you show each person in your family that they are loved?